The Mistress of Species



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Has six newly discovered species to her name, including a wasp, a spider and a butterfly

Dhriti Banerjee, *53*
Director, Zoological Survey of India

PROVIDENCE HAS PLAYED a big role in Dhriti Banerjee's life and work. She was naturally inclined towards Zoology but hadn't actively thought about pursuing the male-dominated science. Till they opened up a quota for women in the year that she was to graduate. Then, when she completed her graduation, she got a letter of employment from the Zoological Survey of India ahead of a confirmation for the post of lecturer in the subject. Having joined ZSI in 1998, she rose to become its head in 2021, a first for an institution that started hiring women only in 1949.

And the accolades haven't stopped coming, whether it was the Nari Shakti Samman or the H.R. Mehra and the T.N. Ananthakrishnan awards in 2022 or the felicitation by the Bharat Chamber of Commerce as an outstanding woman achiever. This year, she signed an MoU with the Natural History Museum, London, for faunal diversity research via scientific exchange. "A major part of Indian fauna was studied during the British Raj," says Dhriti. "Many of these specimens are in the British Museum. This format of collaboration is a breakthrough."

With an experience spanning taxonomy, species distribution, geospatial modelling, monitoring of species and biodiversity conservation, Dhriti also has six newly discovered species in her name, including a wasp, a fish in the Northeast, a butterfly, a crustacean called *Tortanus dhritiae*, the spider *Phintella dhritiae* and a bryozoan, *Plumatella dhritiae*.

Alongside, she is also shattering a few stereotypes about women in leadership roles. "One of my first challenges," she reveals, "was not science, but finance and projects. ZSI had received its largest grant of Rs 25 crore in 2009-10. I was tasked to oversee its implementation to the last penny. I remember sitting nervously at the bank on the last day of the project for the Letter of Credit to be approved. Barring a few, everyone doubted my ability to execute it. But I did."

Always dressed immaculately in handloom saris, Dhriti is an ardent Durga devotee, organising a high-profile pujo in her family home for the past three years. "My in-laws' family had an unbroken tradition of holding a pujo for the past 300 years. When asked to take over, I was nervous, but then I sat with pen and paper, and organised it like I would a conference. It worked!" ■

–Jumana Shah

THE WINNING FACTOR

"Empathy. Treat your team with great respect to earn their love and respect"

BEST HOLIDAY
A family trip to Benares where everyone went temple-hopping, but she and her father stayed behind to read Satyajit Ray's Feluda series